

POWERPLAY: OFFICIAL INSTRUCTION MANUAL

I. INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING (GAME SETUP)

1. Establish Liquidity (The Supply)

- Create three distinct, easily accessible supply piles for the tokens: **Power (P)**, **Influence (IP)**, and **Coins (C)**. This is the central bank.
- **Coin Denominations:** The Coin supply should consist of 30 tokens of **1-value** and 20 tokens of **5-value**.

2. Prepare the Paperwork (The Decks)

- Separately shuffle the **Action Deck**, **Reaction Deck**, and **Event Deck**. Place them face down in the center of the table.
 - **Action Deck:** 15 unique cards × 3 copies = **45 cards total**
 - **Reaction Deck:** 16 unique cards × 2 copies = **32 cards total**
 - **Event Deck:** 15 unique cards × 1 copy = **15 cards total**
- Separate the **Asset Cards** into three distinct draw piles based on their Tier (Level 1, Level 2, and Level 3). Shuffle each pile individually and place them face down.
 - **Level 1 Asset Deck:** 8 unique cards × 2 copies = **16 cards total**
 - **Level 2 Asset Deck:** 8 unique cards × 2 copies = **16 cards total**
 - **Level 3 Asset Deck:** 5 unique cards × 2 copies = **10 cards total**

3. Open the Market (The Deal Flow)

- Draw cards from the top of the Asset piles and place them face up to create the starting Market:
 - **Three (3)** Level 1 Assets
 - **Two (2)** Level 2 Assets
 - **One (1)** Level 3 Asset

4. Determine the Market Leader (First Player Selection)

- The Board must establish dominance early. Players may collectively agree on *one* of the following metrics to determine who picks their Character first and takes the first turn:
 - **Liquid Assets:** Whoever currently has a physical \$100 bill on their person.
 - **Global Footprint:** Whoever went on a foreign trip most recently. (*Loophole: Any player currently visiting from a foreign country automatically wins this category.*)
 - **Depreciating Assets:** Whoever owns the most expensive car.
 - **Wearable Wealth:** Whoever is wearing the most expensive watch.
 - **The Power Move:** Whoever went to the toilet last.
- Place the **Leader Token** in front of the player selected based on the rules above.

5. The Org Chart (Character Selection & Starting Capital)

- Starting with the First Player and proceeding clockwise, players select one **Character** from the available roster.
 - **HR Addendum (The "Tom" Rule):** Anyone named "Tom" must pick their character *last*, regardless of the First Player metric. However, this penalty only applies to character selection; Tom retains their standard seat in the clockwise turn order.
- Once Characters are selected, each player collects their **Starting Stats** (Coins, Influence, and Power tokens) exactly as printed on their Character card.

6. Distribute Initial Portfolios (Starting Hands)

- Every player draws exactly **Three (3) Action cards** and **Two (2) Reaction cards** to form their starting hand. Keep these hidden.

7. Commence Hostilities

- Turn order proceeds clockwise (to the left) starting from the First Player.
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II. GLOSSARY OF TERMS (THE LEGAL FRAMEWORK)

- **Attacker:** Player who played the Action card.
 - **Bankrupt:** A state a player enters when they must pay Coins and cannot, even after liquidating all Assets. This results in player elimination.
 - **Bonus Effect:** Optional additional effect requiring extra cost.
 - **Cancel:** Stops an Action entirely.
 - **Character Action:** As 1 of your actions during your Action Phase, you may use this ability. You may only use your Character Action once per turn.
 - **Defender:** Player targeted by the Action.
 - **Frozen:** A Frozen Asset and any attachments cannot be Used this turn.
 - **Information:** Private knowledge a player holds — such as the contents of their hand, their current resource totals, cards they have seen, or their future intentions. Information has no token representation but is a tradeable commodity.
 - **Lose:** A player reduces their Coins, Influence (IP), or Power (P). The card text will specify the amount and destination.
 - **Prevent:** Blocks a specific effect (loss or damage).
 - **Redirect:** Sends an Action's effect to another player.
 - **Reaction:** A card played from the hand at any time, out of turn sequence, in response to an Action or another Reaction. Reactions may be played to protect yourself or another player (and their Assets). Reaction cards are the primary exception to turn-based play.
 - **Refuse:** The Defender ignores the Action but suffers its Refusal Penalty (not used on Reaction cards).
 - **Replace:** Discard 1 card of the specified type (e.g., Action) from your hand to draw 1 new card of that same type from its deck.
 - **Sell:** As 1 of your actions during your Action Phase, you may Sell one Asset you own. You may sell to the bank (return the Asset card to the supply and gain Coins equal to its printed cost) or to another player (they pay you the printed cost and receive the Asset).
 - **Trigger:** An automatic ability that occurs when a specific game condition is met. The player does not spend an Action to make it happen.
 - **Use:** Activate an Asset's ability or generate its income.
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III. THE ROUND STRUCTURE

A standard Round of PowerPlay consists of three distinct phases, representing a complete fiscal quarter.

1. Inception Phase

- **Market Shock:** Draw exactly **One (1) Universal Event** card and resolve its effects immediately. *If the Event deck is empty, shuffle its discard pile to form a new draw pile first, then draw.*
- **The Pre-Market:** Players may purchase assets from the face-up Asset Market. This purchasing phase proceeds clockwise, starting strictly with the player holding the **Leader Token**.

2. Opening Bell (Player Turns)

- During this phase, all players take **two turns**.
- The sequence of turns proceeds clockwise starting from the **First Player** (the player holding the Leader Token).
- Once every player has taken their first turn, the sequence immediately resets back to the **First Player** to begin the second pass around the table.
- In **Blitz Mode** only, the second turn in each round is called the **Market Reversal**: turn order reverses — the last player to take their first turn goes first in the second pass, then players proceed counter-clockwise (to the right), so the Leader plays last before Call-it-a-Night.
- A player's turn consists of three sub-phases: **Initiate**, **Action**, and **Conclude**.

3. Call-it-a-Night (End of Round)

Once every player has completed their **second** Conclude phase, the Round enters the Call-it-a-Night phase:

- **The Earnings Call (Optional but Encouraged):** Players may openly brag about their current wealth, status, or achievements.
- **Currency Conversion:** Players may freely convert Tokens at the standard exchange rates (3 Coins = 1 Influence | 2 Influence = 1 Power).
- **Thievery:** If the player with the *lowest* total Power is not already the 1st Player, they must steal the **Leader Token** and assign it to any player of their choice — including themselves. *If multiple players are tied for lowest Power, the player among them who is earliest*

in turn order must make the assignment.

- **Market Refresh:** All face-up Asset cards currently in the Market are discarded to their respective Asset discard piles (L1, L2, or L3). Then the Market is restocked: draw 3 cards from the L1 deck, 2 from the L2 deck, and 1 from the L3 deck into the Market face-up. If a draw pile is empty, shuffle its discard pile to form a new draw pile before drawing.
 - *If this is not the final round, a new Round begins with the Inception Phase.*
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IV. TURN STRUCTURE (THE OPENING BELL)

When it is your turn, you must complete the following phases in order:

A. Initiate Phase

- **Draw:** Draw one card of your choice (Action OR Reaction) from the top of the respective deck. *If the deck is empty, shuffle its discard pile to form a new draw pile, then draw. Note: You have an infinite maximum hand size during your turn until the Conclude phase.*
- **Collect Revenue:** Roll a 1d6 to determine market strength on the Fiscal Table and collect the corresponding income in Coins for all active, unfrozen Assets you own.

B. Action Phase

You may perform exactly **One (1) Standard Action** per turn. (*Note: Action cards, Character Actions, or specific Asset triggers may grant additional actions — e.g., via Events or the Investment Bank. When a source grants +1 Action, your budget increases even if you have already spent your standard action; you may then take another.*) Choose one of the following:

- **Buy an Asset:** Purchase one Asset from the Market by paying its printed cost.
- **Buy a Reaction Card:** Pay 2 Coins to the supply to draw the top card of the Reaction Deck. *If the deck is empty, shuffle its discard pile first, then draw.*
- **Buy an Action Card:** Pay 1 Coin to the supply to draw the top card of the Action Deck. *If the deck is empty, shuffle its discard pile first, then draw.*
- **Play an Action Card:** Play one Action card from your hand, pay its cost, and resolve its effects. *You cannot play an Action card that targets a player who has no valid targets for that card (e.g., Hostile Takeover requires the target to own at least one L1 or L2 Asset).*
- **Take a Character Action:** Use your unique Character Ability.
- **Sell an Asset:** Liquidate an Asset you own (to the bank or another player) for its exact printed cost.
- **Corporate Debt (Take a Loan):** Take a loan from the supply against one of your Assets for up to half of its printed cost (rounded down). *Terms: You must repay the principal amount + 1 Coin in exactly two rounds. A mortgaged asset still earns income and can use its ability. If a mortgaged asset is sold, the loan is paid off first, and the seller keeps the remaining profit. An asset with an active loan cannot be used to secure another loan.*
- **Skip:** Do nothing and take 2 Coins from the supply as a consulting fee.

C. Conclude Phase

- **Filing Deadlines:** Discard your hand down to exactly **3 Action Cards** and **2 Reaction Cards**. (*Hand limits are fixed at 3A/2R for all player counts.*)
 - **Debt Collection:** You must pay back any Loans that have come due this round. If you cannot afford the repayment, you default: you must forfeit the Asset the loan was taken against and place it in the Asset discard pile.
 - **Unfreeze Assets:** All of your frozen Assets are unfrozen at the end of your Conclude phase.
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V. FISCAL TIMELINE & GAME MODES

THE STANDARD FISCAL CYCLE (6 Rounds)

- **Player Count:** Requires **3 to 5 players**. The game does not support fewer than 3 or more than 5 active seats. Any additional participants must join as **spectators only**.
- **Duration:** The game concludes at the end of the 6th *Call-it-a-Night* phase. With two turns per round, this provides 12 total turns — enough for the Loan mechanic and high-yield Level 3 Assets to pay off while keeping the pace brisk.

ALTERNATE BOARD RESOLUTIONS

- **The Blitz Mode (4 Rounds):** Highly recommended for 5 players. Silicon Valley pacing. During Blitz, the second turn in each round is the **Market Reversal**: turn order reverses counter-clockwise so the Leader plays last before Call-it-a-Night. Taking a loan late in the game is a massive liability. Players must rely on aggressive Action cards and rapid asset flipping.
- **Long-Term Investment (8 Rounds):** Highly recommended for 3 players. A classic wealth-building cycle designed for players who want to construct massive, interlocking portfolios and weather multiple crashes from the Event deck.

VI. CLEAN THE BOOKS

Before the Board Meeting can begin, the board must be perceived as beyond reproach. After the final Call-it-a-Night phase, **all players must immediately settle every outstanding loan**, regardless of its original due date.

- **Forced Repayment:** Each player pays the principal + 1 Coin repayment cost for every mortgaged Asset they own.
- **Default:** If a player cannot afford repayment on a loan, they must forfeit the mortgaged Asset to the discard pile. The loan is considered discharged upon forfeiture.
- **Order:** Debts are resolved in turn order, one player at a time.

No new loans may be taken during Clean the Books.

VII. THE BOARD MEETING (END GAME SCORING)

When Clean the Books concludes, players must liquidate their empires and calculate their Total Power to determine the winner.

The Final Valuation Formula: $\text{Total Power} = (\text{Power Tokens}) + (\text{Influence Tokens} / 2) + (\text{Coins} / 5) + (\text{Total Value of Assets} / 5)$ (Note: Always round down. The board does not reward fractions of a success).

The player with the most Total Power is declared the **POWER PLAYER**.

Tie-Breaker Protocol: In the event of a tie, corporate litigation is settled via a Best-of-3 match of **Rock, Paper, Scissors, Lizard, Spock**.

VIII. INFORMATION IS POWER (INTEL TRADING)

In PowerPlay, information is a valuable commodity. Players may trade **Information for resources** with any other player **at any time** — during their own turn, during another player's turn, or between phases. No action is spent to initiate a trade.

What counts as Information:

- Revealing one or more cards from your hand (Action or Reaction cards)
- Disclosing your current resource totals (Coins, Influence, Power)
- Sharing knowledge of cards you have seen (e.g., via a Character Ability or Asset effect)
- Revealing your intentions, plans, or strategy

The Deal: Players negotiate freely. Either party may propose the exchange. Terms — what information is revealed and what resources change hands — are decided entirely by mutual agreement. There is no fixed rate.

Binding vs. Non-Binding: The information exchange itself (revealing or sharing) and any immediate resource payment are binding the moment both parties agree. Any *future* promises attached to a deal (e.g., "I won't target you next round") are **verbal and non-binding** — PowerPlay does not enforce future commitments.

Bankruptcy

If a player enters a **negative balance**, they have until the **next Conclude phase of their turn** to recover:

- **If they go negative on their own turn:** They have until the Conclude phase of that same turn to resolve the debt.
- **If they go negative on another player's turn** (e.g., from an Event, Reaction, or another player's Action): They have until the Conclude phase of their **next** turn to resolve the debt.

During that window, the player must:

1. Sell Assets to regain a positive balance
2. Attempt trades with other players
3. Take a Loan against an asset for half its cost (the loan comes due in 2 rounds during the Conclude phase of their turn)

If the player **liquidates all assets and remains negative** by the end of their recovery window, they must either:

- Secure funding from another player
- Take a loan (if they still have assets to collateralise)
- Exit the game (elimination)